

DRAWN FROM THE PAST

Neopaganism

▼ Summer solstice

The solstices—extreme points of the seasonal cycles—are of supreme importance to druids. Here, druids commemorate the summer solstice—the date with the longest hours of daylight—at the ancient site of Stonehenge in southwest England.

The term Neopaganism refers to modern-day beliefs in a pre-Judaic, pre-Christian, pre-Islamic past. Wicca (see pp.264–267) comes under the Neopagan umbrella. Neopaganism began as 1960s Western counterculture developed, a time when many people rejected established authority in search of a new, free spirituality and meaning in an otherwise material world. It surged in popularity during the 1990s and continues to do so in the 21st century. Neopaganism rarely has creeds or dogmas, but certain features are common to all of its various forms. Followers are usually

polytheistic (believe in many deities) or pantheistic (see god in everything); they honor both male and female; they venerate nature, including humans and their ancestral spirits, and regard it as divine in itself. Above all, Neopagans promote magic as a vital force in the world.

Druids, Wicca, nature, and bygone ages

Unlike believers in a New Age (see pp.284–287), who look to the future, Neopagans take their inspiration from the ancient world. Druidism (the practices of Celtic teachers, priests, or wise men)

